AJP Policy Document

Protect and restore natural habitats

AJP supports greater protection and restoration of natural habitats and ecosystems. We recognise that the destruction or degradation of habitats and ecosystems causes direct harm to wild animals, and that both humans and wild animals are sustained by natural habitats and ecosystems.

63% of Aotearoa's land area has now been converted for human use, with animal agriculture being a primary historical cause of habitat destruction.[1] By 1930, 39% of New Zealand's land area had been cleared and transformed to make way for pastoral farming.[2] This transformation of land involved destroying forests, draining wetlands and disrupting waterways, causing significant harm to natural ecosystems and free living animals, whose habitats were obliterated or disrupted. As of 2021, this remains largely unaddressed, with 42% of land converted for farming and 8% converted for forestry.[3] In order to reverse this process, AJP would enable greater protection of native ecosystems along with the restoration of ecosystems, especially in areas currently used for animal agriculture. Pastoral farming is a highly inefficient use of land for food production,[4] using far more land compared to other crops, but producing a fraction of the calories. Moving towards a plant-based food system and away from animal agriculture would allow us to free up significant areas of land to re-wild.

Ocean and freshwater ecosystems must be protected against the destructive impacts of fishing and pollution. Industrial fishing kills vast numbers of fishes and other marine animals, disrupts marine ecosystems and destroys seafloor habitats.[5] Mining further threatens seafloor habitats and the animals that rely on them. Marine environments are

[1] 'Habitat loss'. Environment Guide. (2018). https://www.environmentguide.org.nz/issues/biodiversity/key-threats/habitat-loss/
[2] Julia Haggerty and Hugh Campbell, 'Farming and the environment', Te Ara - the Encyclopedia of New Zealand, http://www.TeAra.govt.nz/en/farming-and-the-environment/print (accessed 15 February 2025)
[3] Chapter 3: Our activities and their effects. (2021, April 15). Ministry for the Environment. https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-land-2021/chapter-3-our-activities-and-their-effects/#land-use-and-changes-in-land-use
[4] Hannah Ritchie (2021) - "If the world adopted a plant-based diet, we would reduce global agricultural land use from 4 to 1 billion hectares" Published online at OurWorldinData.org. Retrieved from: https://ourworldindata.org/land-use-diets
[5] Jennings, S., & Kaiser, M. J. (2017). The effects of fishing on marine ecosystems. ICES Journal of Marine Science, 74(9), 2283-2297; Oberle, F. K. J., Storlazzi, C. D., & Hanebuth, T. J. J. (2016). What a drag—Quantifying the global impact of chronic bottom trawling on continental shelf sediment. *Journal of Marine Systems*, 154, 243-257.

heavily polluted due to plastics and microplastics,[6] oil spills,[7] and eutrophication due to farm run off and aquaculture farms.[8] These activities harm the animals living in aquatic ecosystems, and, by degrading them, in turn harm humans and animals in other ecosystems that indirectly rely on healthy oceans, rivers and lakes. These vital ecosystems must be protected and, where relevant, active steps should be taken to restore them.

In summary, AJP advocates for steps to be taken to halt further land and marine-habitat destruction, facilitate a shift towards plant-based agriculture to alleviate the impact of animal agriculture on habitats and to free up land, and will actively work to preserve and restore land and marine habitats.

Key Objectives:

1. **Restrict** further habitat destruction, of both terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems.
2. **Ban** bottom trawling
3. **Restrict** seabed mining
4. **Redirect** funds away from animal agriculture, through taxes and regulations, and towards plant-based agriculture and habitat restoration projects and practices, as outlined in our '*Introduce tighter standards and enforcement for agricultural pollution' and 'Provide financial incentives for good environmental practices' sub-policies under Objective 2 in our 'Just Transition to a Plant-Based Economy' policy*. This redirection of funds would enable:
    a. Reserves: Stronger protection of, and creation of more, land and marine reserves (including more Highly Protected Marine Areas)
    b. Restoration: Roll out restoration projects to restore habitats, including mangroves, peat bogs, forests, marine habitats and other natural ecosystems. Subsidise farmers and landowners actively restoring the land and associated ecosystems.
    c. Subsidise green community projects
    d. Create wildlife corridors (link to Objective 3: *Protect Wildlife From Anthropogenic Harms*)
5. **Implement** educational programmes in schools, universities, and communities to promote awareness of the importance of living within our ecological limits, for the purpose of avoiding, remedying and mitigating the destruction of natural environments in which animals live. *See Compassionate Education policy.*

[6] IUCN. (2024). Over 460 million metric tons of plastic are produced every year for use in a wide variety of applications. An estimated 20 million metric tons of plastic litter end up in the environment every year. CN. Plastic pollution resource brief.
[7] Lovindeer, R., Mynott, S., Porobic, J., Fulton, E. A., & others. (2023). Ecosystem-level impacts of oil spills: A review of available data with confidence metrics for application to ecosystem models. *Environmental Modeling & Assessment, 28*, 939–960. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10666-023-09905-1
[8] Wang, W. F. (2024). Eutrophication mechanisms and their impacts on coastal marine ecosystems. International Journal of Marine Science, 14(4), 285–294. https://doi.org/10.5376/ijms.2024.14.0032